

At Capacity? Airbnb's Search for New Growth Paths

"I basically started saying, 'What if you could Airbnb the world? What if you could have Airbnb for everything?'" -Brian Chesky, CEO Airbnb, June 2025¹

Airbnb, a company that operated an online marketplace for short-term and long-term overnight stays, went public on December 10, 2020, through an IPO (initial public offering) of \$68 per share. The reaction to this listing was as impressive as it was surprising. Covid-19 produced lockdowns during 2020, and the sector had been battered by reduced travel and limited growth. Despite this, Airbnb shares soared on their debut during the busiest December of IPO history, closing the day at \$144.71, more than doubling the valuation from just a few days earlier and bringing the total value of the company to over \$100 billion. The IPO immediately surpassed the valuations of other major brands, including Expedia (\$18 billion) and Delta Airlines (\$30 billion), as well as the combined worth of Marriott, Hilton, and Hyatt. Acting as an intermediary between hosts and guests and charging a commission for each booking, the platform eventually grew to over 8 million active listings and over 150 million users worldwide, upending the hospitality and tourism industry.²

In response to the IPO, CEO Brian Chesky had claimed, "the higher the stock price, the higher the expectations."³ He may not have known just how right this statement would come to be. Following the IPO, Airbnb struggled to keep up with investor expectations and the changing travel industry landscape. Although Airbnb enjoyed respectable revenue growth of 18% and 11% during 2023 and 2024, the value of its stock had not kept up (see Exhibit 1). Since the organization's high of \$212.68 per share barely two months after the IPO in 2020, the stock had fallen to \$131.41 per share by the end of 2024. Between the IPO in 2020 and 2024, market value had fallen overall (see Exhibit 2). To make matters worse, strong competitors such as Expedia, Marriott, and Hilton had made significant stock gains over the previous five years, jumping 46.4%, 107.1%, and 130.9%, respectively.⁴

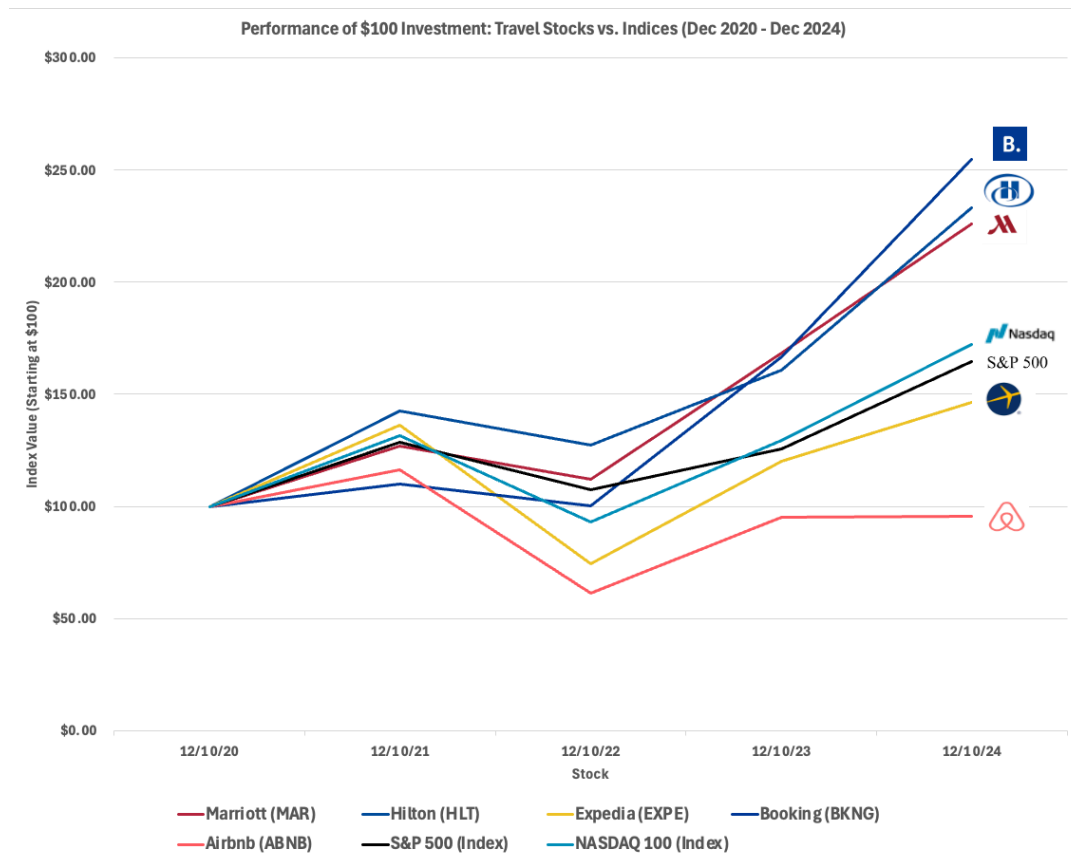
Airbnb had once been considered the biggest disruptor in the travel industry, taking business away from the largest names in the sector. But in the years following the pandemic, the company had begun to struggle to keep investors, regulators, and consumers satisfied. Local government pushback, increasing competition, and a slew of safety and regulatory concerns, began to create significant concerns about the future.

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By 2025, Chesky faced several difficult questions. Could Airbnb maintain growth in its hospitality business in the short- and long-term? Could that growth finally result in higher stock prices and shareholder value? With its well-established platform, highly focused on lodging, Chesky wondered where he might find new growth opportunities. What could be done to reignite Airbnb as a platform leader?

Exhibit 1: Airbnb Stock Value Performance Compared to Competitors (2020-2024)



Source: CSI Market (https://csimarket.com/stocks/competitionSEG2.php?code=ABNB#google_vignette)

* Values are taken from the closing price on December 10 each year, aligning with the date of Airbnb's IPO

Airbnb Company Background

In 2007, roommates Brian Chesky and Joe Gebbia began searching for ways to pay their rent in bustling Silicon Valley. Fortunately for them, the Industrial Designers Society of America Conference took place that month. Because of the immense number of people it brought into the city, hotel rooms were in short supply. This situation inspired Brian Chesky and Joe Gebbia to rent out air mattresses in their apartment to provide lodging for conference-goers, offering an affordable and unique alternative to hotels. Their first customers were three attendees of the conference: a woman from Boston, a father from Utah, and a man from India. This small-scale experiment proved successful and sparked the idea that travelers might prefer unique, local experiences over hotels.⁵

Encouraged by their initial success, Chesky and Gebbia brought in Nathan Blecharczyk, a technical architect and Harvard graduate, as the third co-founder to help build a platform where

hosts could offer stays, and guests could find lodging. Together, they launched the first version of Airbedandbreakfast.com in August 2008 during the Democratic National Convention in Denver, Colorado. With over 20,000 attendees and limited accommodation, their site attracted a handful of new users. Although the initial launch wasn't a massive success, it confirmed the potential of the idea.⁶

Exhibit 2: Market Cap in Billions (2020-2024)

Year	Expedia (EXPE)	Marriott (MAR)	Hilton (HLT)	Booking.com (BKNG)	Airbnb (ABNB)
2020	\$ 18.72	\$ 42.78	\$ 30.86	\$ 91.21	\$ 87.70
2021	\$ 27.38	\$ 53.81	\$ 43.47	\$ 98.52	\$ 105.78
2022	\$ 13.67	\$ 47.12	\$ 34.17	\$ 78.17	\$ 54.13
2023	\$ 21.07	\$ 66.23	\$ 46.69	\$ 123.76	\$ 73.34
2024	\$ 23.88	\$ 78.82	\$ 60.93	\$ 166.72	\$ 83.33

*Values are taken from the end of the year

The Peer-to-Peer Economy

With its disruptive business model, Airbnb became part of a wave of peer-to-peer (P2P) sharing apps like Uber (rides) and Turo (rental cars), which revolutionized industries by leveraging smartphone technology to facilitate the sharing of assets and resources among individuals. The sharing economy operated by creating digital platforms that enabled users to buy, sell, rent, or share goods and services directly with one another, bypassing traditional intermediaries in favor of digital interactions. These digital platforms built trust through features like verified reviews, secure payment systems, and user ratings, fostering reliability in transactions. By enabling cost-effective options and promoting resource optimization, sharing platforms made services and assets more accessible while fostering community connections and reducing waste (see Exhibit 3).

Exhibit 3: Examples of Peer-to-Peer Sharing⁷

	Uber	Airbnb	Turo
Estimated Users (2024)	161 Million	265 Million	3.5 Million
Estimated Valuation (2024)	\$136 Billion	\$83 Billion	\$2.7 Billion (Estimated)
Industry	Transportation	Hospitality	Car Sharing
Founding Year	2009	2008	2010

Source: LightCastle Partners (<https://lightcastlepartners.com/insights/2020/02/emergence-sharing-economy/>, in addition to annual company filings and case writer estimates)

Airbnb's model tapped into a new market by leveraging an underutilized resource — spare rooms in homes. Unlike established businesses in the hospitality industry, Airbnb allowed everyday people to become hosts, offering travelers more affordable, personalized, and unique

lodging options. This early move also gave Airbnb an advantage in brand recognition and the network effects that come from having more hosts attracting more guests (and vice versa). Airbnb had built a two-sided peer-to-peer marketplace. One side consisted of hosts offering lodging space; the other consisted of guests seeking short-term stays. These two groups interacted through listings, requests, bookings, and payments, with the platform coordinating the exchange.

Airbnb Early Days

The novelty of the concept created serious early obstacles. Asking strangers to trust each other inside private homes was a bold departure from traditional hospitality offerings and initially triggered skepticism, safety concerns, and security questions, especially since verification mechanisms were still limited. Those trust and safety issues made early adoption difficult. This slowed traction and produced uneven revenue at a time when the company needed consistent growth. With limited funding, Airbnb was forced to rely on outside investment to keep building.

Over time, Airbnb overcame these hurdles by creating a more trusted marketplace and solving the operational complexity of running it—managing listings at scale, processing payments reliably, and using reviews and other reputation mechanisms to reduce uncertainty for both sides. Doing this well required significant technological innovation. The combination of well-executed discovery tools for users, trust mechanisms, and platform architecture helped make Airbnb's model distinctive and difficult for competitors to quickly copy.

Airbnb's breakthrough came in 2009 when it was admitted into Y Combinator, a prestigious startup accelerator.⁸ Under the guidance of Paul Graham, the company learned to focus on improving its product and solving real problems for users. Executives shortened the company name to Airbnb, expanded their offerings beyond air mattresses to include entire homes, apartments, and unique accommodations, and worked relentlessly to enhance the platform. The following year, Sequoia Capital invested another \$7.2M in a Series A fund, allowing Airbnb to launch its services in Europe and other key markets, further accelerating growth.⁹

Airbnb's Market Expansion

By 2011, the platform had undergone a major redesign, creating a sleek, user-friendly interface that improved the user experience. That same year, the company surpassed one million bookings and opened offices in major cities like London, Paris, and Berlin, solidifying its international presence. By 2012, Airbnb had achieved a major milestone with 10 million nights booked.¹⁰ However, this rapid growth brought increased scrutiny, as cities began examining Airbnb's impact on local housing. This often compelled the company to navigate and respond to emerging regulatory challenges.

From 2013 to 2015, Airbnb transitioned from a fast-growing startup to a household name. In 2013, they unveiled their new logo and brand identity, "Bélo," a logo representing a person, a heart, and the letter A, which symbolized the idea of belonging anywhere.¹¹ This rebranding coincided with an additional \$200 million funding round, valuing the company at \$2.5 billion and enabling further expansion.¹² In 2014, the company began adding various new features to enrich its offerings, such as curated travel guides for popular destinations. These new features appeared to strengthen the appeal of the platform for existing users in the core interaction of short-term rentals. In 2015, Airbnb entered the Chinese market under the brand "Aibiyang" (爱彼迎), which translated to "welcome each other with love." These expansion offerings caused Airbnb to reach a staggering valuation of \$25.5 billion.¹³

Airbnb's growth continued as it added new services (types of interactions) between 2016 and 2019. In 2016, the company launched Experiences, a new interaction allowing users to book

unique local tours and activities curated by hosts. Initially, the service relied on established lodging hosts to provide tour offerings, but later the platform opened to independent tour guides and operators. By separating tour offerings from property offerings, the platform had added a new “side” of producers to engage in the previously added interaction of Experiences. Airbnb Experiences proved popular, growing to over 40,000 experiences by the end of 2019. In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, Airbnb shifted some of these experiences online, launching Airbnb “Online Experiences,” such as Zoom-guided tours or cooking classes, which featured virtual offerings hosted on the platform. However, Airbnb Experiences did not remain a focal point indefinitely. Despite efforts to expand Experiences, the company admitted in annual reports that substantially all of the bookings and revenue on the platform came from overnight stays, implying little traction for Experiences. By 2023, Airbnb temporarily halted new applications for Experiences, citing their focus on “perfecting the core service.”¹⁴

In 2017, Airbnb introduced two premium tiers: Airbnb Plus – listings inspected in person against a 100-plus-point checklist – and, following its acquisition of Luxury Retreats, Beyond by Airbnb (later, Airbnb Luxe), which offered professionally managed luxury properties, where property managers listed property on behalf of hosts, and inhouse concierges helped with travel arrangements.¹⁵ To expand its reach in the broader travel market, Airbnb acquired HotelTonight in 2018, a last-minute hotel booking app. This acquisition allowed Airbnb to expand its travel portfolio to include traditional and boutique hotel listings in its portfolio as well as strengthen its competitive positioning against other hotel booking competitors such as Booking.com and Expedia.¹⁶ For most hotel bookings Airbnb continued to direct guests to the HotelTonight app to make their reservation. By 2019, Airbnb had hosted over 500 million guest arrivals worldwide, demonstrating its dominance in the short-term rental market. The company began preparing for an initial public offering, signaling the next phase of its growth.¹⁷

The Covid-19 Pandemic

Airbnb encountered significant challenges in getting the then-12-year-old company onto Wall Street. After a meteoric rise in popularity, Airbnb's revenue had grown steadily from 2016 to 2019 but fell sharply during the first nine months of 2020 – just two months before its IPO – because of the COVID-19 pandemic. The pandemic shook the tourism industry to its core, resulting in a staggering \$1.3 trillion loss in global tourism revenue, more than 11 times greater than the losses seen during the 2009 global economic crisis.¹⁸

For a company that had already been grappling with user trust issues, the idea of renting private homes during a rapidly spreading virus led Airbnb to lose considerable momentum. Unlike commercial settings, where licensed tourist accommodations adhered to strict health and safety regulations, Airbnb settings in private homes seemed to pose greater health risks, as those properties had not been designed with pandemic-ready standards in mind. To address these concerns and adapt to the pandemic's challenges, Airbnb had introduced a “quarantine and isolation stay” model.¹⁹ This initiative focused on providing secure, sanitized spaces for individuals who needed to isolate due to COVID-19 exposure, for healthcare workers who required temporary housing near hospitals, and for travelers who had been stranded by lockdowns.

To bolster trust, Airbnb implemented new safety protocols such as enhanced cleaning practices guided by health authorities. The company allowed hosts to designate properties as meeting “Enhanced Clean” standards.²⁰ The platform also introduced flexible cancellation policies to accommodate sudden travel restrictions or health emergencies, aligning with the evolving needs of a cautious customer base. While the model had been praised for addressing immediate housing needs, it had faced criticism over potential gaps in enforcing health standards across its decentralized network of host-owned properties. Ultimately, the approach demonstrated

Airbnb's adaptability in navigating a global crisis while exposing the complexities of maintaining user confidence in such an environment.

More Feature Innovation

In the years that followed, Airbnb continued to innovate. In 2021, as travel began to rebound after the pandemic, the company introduced a feature of flexible search options, including the "Live Anywhere" initiative, to address shifts in consumer behavior emphasizing the need for greater travel flexibility. As the lines between traveling and living blurred, Airbnb began to treat them as one and the same, a perspective it shared with its customer base. This offering was built on four key assumptions: "the rise of remote work enables people to travel anytime; travelers are increasingly drawn to less popular destinations, spurred by the growth of travel blogging; long-term stays often result in visitors temporarily 'living' in their destinations; and family travel has become the primary driver of the travel industry's recovery post-pandemic." This approach reflected a broader trend in the travel industry, where consumers prioritized flexibility amid uncertainties surrounding global travel restrictions and evolving personal schedules.²¹

Building on this momentum, Airbnb launched new rental categories such as Airbnb Rooms in 2022 and 2023, further expanding its features. Airbnb Rooms allowed guests to book private rooms within shared homes, providing a more affordable and social travel option compared to renting an entire property. Based on the original design of Airbnb to be housed alongside a host, this new category also offered hosts an opportunity to earn extra income by renting out individual rooms to different guests at the same time. The introduction of enhanced search features and a wider range of accommodations made the platform more accessible, catering to a broader audience, and resulted in steadily growing bookings, users, and listings (See Exhibit 4).²²

Exhibit 4: Airbnb Key Customer Metrics

Year	Annual Users	Active listings	Nights & Experiences Booked
2017	-	4.0	185.8
2018	150	6.0	250.3
2019	-	7.0	326.9
2020	200	5.6	193.2
2021	-	6.0	300.6
2022	230	6.6	393.7
2023	265	7.7	448.0
2024	275	8.1	492.0

Source: <https://www.businessofapps.com/data/airbnb-statistics/>; annual reports

Turning a Profit

Airbnb's journey to profitability was marked by strategic innovation, disciplined operations, and a focus on long-term growth. The company strived to capture higher-margin segments of the travel market, catering to travelers seeking luxury and quality assurance. Additionally, the launch of Experiences was an attempt to diversify Airbnb's revenue streams,

enabling it to monetize interactions that went beyond accommodations, but the contribution to performance had been limited. Strategic acquisitions, such as HotelTonight, further expanded its portfolio, attracting new customer segments and strengthening its competitive position.

The company's efforts came to fruition in 2022, when it turned a \$350 million loss from the previous year into nearly \$2 billion in net income.²³ By narrowing its focus on its core short-term rental business and cutting unnecessary costs, Airbnb had emerged from the pandemic crisis with renewed strength. The company increased their take rate (commission) on host revenue from 12.7% to 14.2% between 2019-2023, further enabling the financial transformation. As travel demand rebounded, Airbnb's ability to balance innovation, market expansion, and operational efficiency seemed to position it as a strong and profitable platform in the peer-to-peer economy (See Exhibit 5).

Exhibit 5: Airbnb Company Financials (Millions)

Category	2023-12-31	2022-12-31	2021-12-31	2020-12-31	2019-12-31
Revenue	\$9917	\$8399	\$5992	\$3378	\$4805
Cost Of Goods Sold	\$1703	\$1499	\$1156	\$876	\$1196
Gross Profit	\$8214	\$6900	\$4836	\$2502	\$3609
Research And Development Expenses	\$1722	\$1502	\$1425	\$2753	\$977
SG&A Expenses	\$4974	\$3507	\$2869	\$3188	\$3134
Operating Expenses	\$6696	\$5098	\$4407	\$6092	\$4110
Operating Income	\$1518	\$1802	\$429	\$-3590	\$-503
Total Non-Operating Income/ Expense	\$584	\$187	\$-729	\$-1092	\$90
Pre-Tax Income	\$2102	\$1989	\$-300	\$-4682	\$-412
Income Taxes	\$-2690	\$96	\$52	\$-97	\$263
Income After Taxes	\$4792	\$1893	\$-352	\$-4585	\$-674
Net Income	\$4792	\$1893	\$-352	\$-4585	\$-674

Source: Stock Analysis (<https://stockanalysis.com/stocks/abnb/financials/>)

Airbnb Internal Challenges

The company's journey didn't come without struggles. As the platform expanded, the need to support its growing host base became increasingly important. Hosts were essential to Airbnb's success, yet nearly 40% of hosts reported dissatisfaction with the platform's customer support and policies, which sometimes resulted in hosts facing financial losses in disputes with guests.²⁴ To address these issues, Airbnb introduced the Airbnb Host Advisory Board, giving

seats at the table to Airbnb hosts. This Board provided a formal link to Airbnb leadership and participated in monthly meetings to present hosts' ideas.

The Host Advisory board led to a plethora of initiatives aimed at addressing common needs of Airbnb hosts, such as the Airbnb Host Guarantee, which offered protection for up to \$1 million in property damage, and Superhost status to recognize top-performing hosts. However, despite these efforts, challenges remained as the platform continued to balance supporting hosts while scaling its operations globally. Although Airbnb promised protection, their liability coverage was considered "secondary," meaning they wanted the host to push all liability to their own homeowner's insurance before stepping in, including injury claims. Oftentimes, the host's insurance would not step in because of the commercial activity the property engaged in. When these claims got denied, Airbnb was often forced to defend itself against lawsuits. Ensuring high-quality standards while retaining its host community remained a crucial task for Airbnb's long-term success.²⁵

Trust and safety concerns had been an ongoing significant challenge for Airbnb. Incidents involving damage to property or criminal activity had raised questions about how safe Airbnb really was for both guests and hosts. In response, Airbnb had implemented several policies aimed at improving trust and safety, including identity verification for users, a 24/7 safety hotline, and comprehensive insurance options like the Airbnb Host Guarantee and Airbnb's Rebooking and Refund Policy, which allowed guests to report issues with the Airbnb host, as well as giving guests automatic refunds for host cancelled reservations. Additionally, Airbnb had rolled out more stringent review systems, requiring guests and hosts to complete reviews before transactions were completed to encourage transparency. Despite these efforts, the company still faced ongoing concerns about safety, particularly in high-risk areas or during special events.

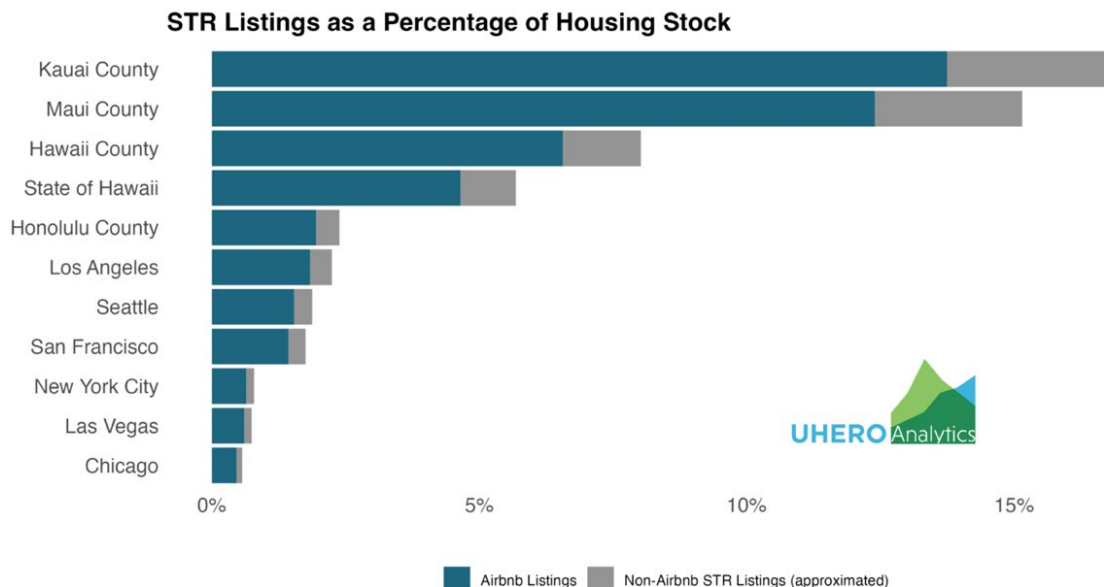
Competition and Regulatory Challenges

In the years prior to 2025, Airbnb also faced mounting challenges from increased competition, shifting consumer demands, and tightening regulatory oversight. Rival platforms such as VRBO and Booking.com capitalized on their established partnerships with traditional hospitality providers, offering broad inventories and loyalty programs that Airbnb struggled to replicate. Niche platforms targeting specific travel preferences, like luxury or eco-friendly stays, further fragmented the market. Meanwhile, traditional hotels regained ground by emphasizing standardized services, professional amenities, and rewards programs, drawing travelers who sought consistency over uncertainty. These competitive pressures were reflected in Airbnb's market performance, with reports showing its share of the short-term rental market narrowing slightly in key regions like Europe and North America.

Airbnb's rapid growth had also created significant challenges in popular tourist destinations, such as Maui, where the platform intensified housing shortages and increased the cost of living. In 2022, Maui had over 2,500 Airbnb listings, and according to the Hawaii Tourism Authority, over 17% of all accommodations on the island were short-term rentals. While Airbnb had provided more affordable and personalized lodging options for tourists, its impact on the local housing market had become deeply troubling. As more properties were converted into short-term rentals, long-term residents were forced to compete for a dwindling supply of available housing, driving rental prices beyond their reach. A report by the University of Hawaii revealed that the median rent for a one-bedroom apartment in Maui had increased by 35% between 2017 and 2022, largely attributed to the surge in short-term rentals. Locals had expressed growing frustration, with one Maui resident saying, "It's getting harder and harder to find a place to live here. Airbnb has made the situation much worse." The platform's role in the housing crisis highlighted the stark contrast between the benefits to travelers and the growing strain on communities, as locals struggled to afford to live in their own neighborhoods (See Exhibit 6).

Regulatory challenges created significant headwinds. In New York City, the number of Airbnb listings had surpassed the number of available apartments in Manhattan, Brooklyn, and northwest Queens. Cities like New York, which had introduced a law requiring hosts to register their properties and limit short-term rentals, significantly restricted Airbnb's operations in urban areas. Similarly, Barcelona, Amsterdam, and Paris had imposed stringent short-term rental limits to combat housing shortages, forcing Airbnb to spend millions on compliance efforts and legal battles. These restrictions also strained relationships with hosts, many of whom had faced rising fees and declining profitability due to increased competition and regulatory costs.

Exhibit 6: Short-Term Rental Listing Local Market Penetration



Source: <https://uhero.hawaii.edu/short-term-vacation-rentals-and-housing-costs-in-hawaii%CA%BBi/#:~:text=Comparing%20STR%20prevalence%20in%20Hawaii,Kauai%20the%20figure%20is%2014%25.>

The Path Ahead

Airbnb's journey from an innovative startup to a global leader in short-term rentals had been marked by remarkable success and significant challenges. Airbnb had capitalized on its unique, peer-to-peer business model, attracting millions of users worldwide. However, its post-IPO journey had been less smooth. The hurdles imposed by the COVID-19 pandemic stalled growth and flattened or decreased stock prices despite steady revenue and profitability increases. The company faced intense competition from established hospitality giants like Marriott and Expedia, as well as growing regulatory pressures and nagging concerns over trust and safety. These challenges loomed large for a company that had already waged a valiant battle in the lodging industry.

Airbnb found itself at a pivotal crossroads. With a stalling share price, increasing competition, and mounting regulatory challenges, the company had to act decisively to maintain its position as a leader in the hospitality space. Airbnb had to find ways to reignite its growth and address its internal and external challenges. Brian Chesky and his team faced a pressing question: How could Airbnb leverage its existing platform, strategy, and resources to secure sustainable growth while defending its competitive advantage in an increasingly crowded market?

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- ¹ <https://www.theverge.com/decoder-podcast-with-nilay-patel/677324/airbnb-ceo-brian-chesky-services-redesign-app-future-travel?>
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 - ²³ <https://stockanalysis.com/stocks/abnb/financials/>
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